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10 Ways to Supercharge Your Career

The best tips from 1,000 episodes of the HBR IdeaCast. *by Alison Beard and Curt Nickisch*

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Yaroslav Danylchenko/Stocksy

Business can change on a dime, and management practices are ever evolving. Still, there are essential leadership, communication, strategy, and problem-solving skills that endure. As we celebrate our 1000th episode of HBR's flagship podcast [*HBR IdeaCast*](#), we identified 10 pieces of timeless advice from the archives to give your career a huge boost.

1. Build a purposeful career.

A job can be just a paycheck, but you'll be happier and more productive in your role if it's more than that. In a 2019 episode, Kellogg School professor Nicholas Pearce explained why individuals should build their careers on purpose:

[T]his idea of authentic life's work is not only letting our best and highest values guide how we do our work and how we behave at work, but letting those values guide what work we do in the first place. It's about the work and the impact we feel most called to make at any given point in our lives. It's the work that we cannot not do. And so, when we're given the gift of letting our souls shine through the work we do, it's authentically ours.

2. Have the difficult conversations at work. You can do it without upsetting people.

Every job is going to require difficult conversations. You have to know how to handle them — first to advocate for yourself and your ideas, and then to become a good team leader who can manage conflict. In 2008, communications consultant Holly Weeks discussed common pitfalls when delivering bad news:

The almost knee-jerk tendency is to try to minimize the bad news or jolly the listeners by making it sound good. ... Now, the big problem with being unclear in a moment like that is that you teach your listeners to guess. The chances that they will guess in favor of your own view are not good. People are very self-interested. And this is how rumors start. This is how constant misinterpretations come up.

3. You can be yourself without oversharing. Know when to self-disclose — and when not to.

Research shows that teams trust leaders who show vulnerability and behave more authentically. But oversharing can backfire. In a 2013 episode, Sy Syms School professor Lisa Rosh explained how trying too hard to be relatable can undermine your authority.

If I had one thing to say to an executive, it is: Do not exaggerate. Do not make up stories. People are smart, they figure it out, and it can do irreparable harm. A less-than-perfect disclosure that fits the emotion of the situation is much better than being disingenuous. The second thing I would say is that the self-disclosure must fit and further the task at hand ... It cannot be for promoting oneself or fulfilling one's need for approval.

4. Want to get better at making decisions? Review your past ones.

Your career is made up of the decisions you make over time. And there are helpful frameworks to make good choices on the fly. But too few people take the time and effort to review their thinking after the fact. Interviewed in 2023, Hasard Lee, a U.S. Air Force fighter pilot trained to make decisions under pressure, said he's never seen a better tool to improve decision making than the debrief:

Go through how you can be better after every project. At the end of every week, write down a few things that you can improve upon. And over the course of a year or two, you'll be surprised at how much improvement you make.

5. The middle of your career is not a point of diminishing returns. It's an opportunity.

At midlife, it's natural to feel like you have fewer paths open to you. But former CEO Chip Conley sees it as a chance to reframe your career with the experience and wisdom you've gained. In 2024, he told the story of his own "midlife edit":

It meant I had to really say goodbye to some identities, and some roles, and some of how I was living my life. ... What it allowed me to do in my 50s is to have a little bit more of a blank slate and say: Okay, so, now that I've junked all these things, how do I want to live my life? What is going to give me meaning in my life?

6. Win over skeptics by collaborating with them.

Over your career, you'll encounter people with diverse experiences and egos. When a colleague has a different view, you may be tempted to argue your position. Instead, it can prove more effective to problem-solve together. In 2022, Oscar-winning film director Ron Howard said he adopted his collaborative leadership style early in his career, when he was directing the star actress Bette Davis.

She thought I was this young guy from a sitcom, and I really had to struggle to sort of earn her respect. Which I ultimately did by using a kind of creative logic of rolling up your sleeves and saying, "Oh, this isn't quite working. How might it work? What should we do? What do you think?" And she wound up being very complimentary of me by the end.

7. Evaluate new roles for their learning potential.

Career paths are a journey, not a climb. So don't think about a potential new role as the rung on a ladder. Think about it more as an opportunity

to learn. Interviewed in 2017, Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella shared how the career choices that expanded his comfort zone cleared his path to the C-suite:

It was not about: This is somehow going to be the next move I need to make in some grand plan to get to the corner office. That definitely was not the case. In fact, I distinctly remember [then Microsoft CEO] Steve [Ballmer] saying, “Hey, look, if you go to Bing and you don’t do a good job or succeed, it might just be your last job.” But what at least drove those choices for me was more about: Hey, what can I learn? Where can I have impact? Where can I uniquely contribute?

8. When your usual options aren’t working, it pays to create new ones.

Sometimes you’re faced with a choice between two subpar options. In 2017, Rotman School professor Jennifer Riel outlined an innovative strategy called integrative thinking:

There are some problems for which making the trade-off is unacceptable. If I make the trade-off, I lose. If I make the trade-off, it’s not going to solve the problem. And it is in that situation where you ask yourself: “Could there be a better way? Could I imagine doing something either than choosing the either/or, or finding the barely acceptable compromise, and actually seek to create a better choice — something new that doesn’t exist today?”

9. To alleviate burnout, learn to identify its root causes.

Many managers struggle to deal with stress and burnout on their team. And it’s often because they don’t fully understand it. Amid the pandemic in 2020, Berkeley professor Christina Maslach explained how burnout is a group phenomenon, not an individual one, and offered some advice for managers:

Try and approach a team or a unit or whatever to sort of say again, checking in, how are things going? What could we begin to do? Where are the little pebbles in your shoe that are really affecting everybody? And what could we begin to think of as possible solutions or innovations that might help that? Then you get away from what I think is one of the major problems with burnout, which is to blame the person and make the individual feel that he or she is inadequate.

10. All profits are not created equal.

To be a great organizational leader, you can't ignore society's changing view of business. One reflection of this is the ongoing debate over shareholder capitalism versus stakeholder capitalism. In a 2011 episode, Harvard Business School professor Michael Porter [explained the idea of "shared value."](#)

[The economist] Milton Friedman famously argued that the social responsibility of business was to maximize its profits, and this simple act of profit maximization was good in and of itself. ... But if you think about creating economic value in a narrow way, if you don't understand really the broader and more subtle and longer-term influences on the ultimate sustainability of a firm's success, you can get into a situation where that profit really does come at the expense of society.

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